

The first humans

Millions of years ago, a group of apes began to walk upright. They were our ancestors, the first human-like animals on the planet. Over time, their bodies adapted to walking upright and their brains grew larger, until finally they evolved into our species, *Homo sapiens*.

LATE ARRIVALS

Our planet was formed just over 4.5 billion years ago. If the whole of Earth's history were squeezed into an hour, most life forms would not develop until the last ten minutes. Humans would not appear until the very last fraction of the last second of the hour.



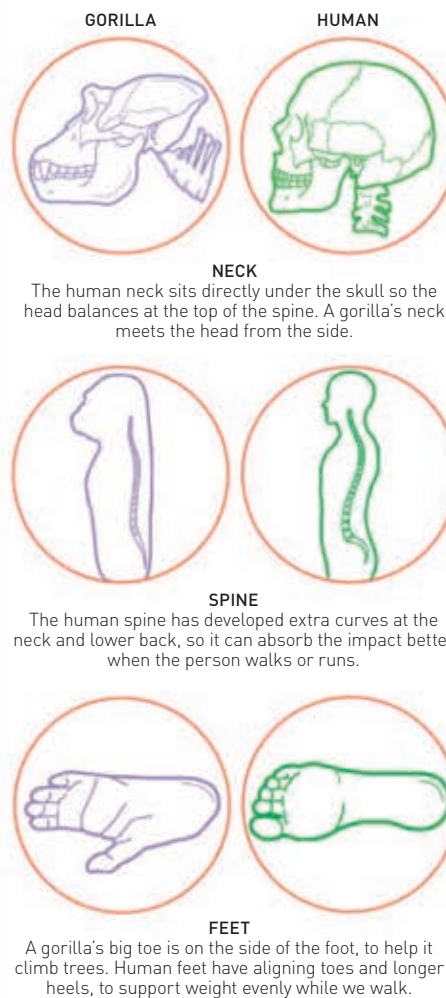
OUT OF AFRICA

Homo sapiens, our species, first evolved in Africa around 150,000 years ago. About 100,000 years later, they began to move away to make new settlements, until humans were living on all the world's continents, except Antarctica.



ON TWO FEET

Humans walk on two legs, unlike other primates (apes), who are either climbers or walk using all four feet. As a result of walking upright, humans' bodies have developed very differently from those of their ape relatives.



EARLY TOOLS

Early humans learned how to make tools by striking a stone with another one to make a cutting edge. Humans began to make different tools for different tasks, such as digging, sawing, or opening nuts.



HOW TO MAKE A HANDAXE

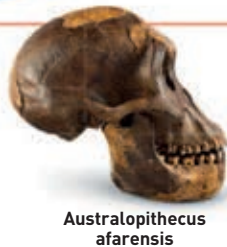
It took skill and experience to select a suitable stone, then chip it to make a sharp, usable tool.



7 MYA (million years ago)
Sahelanthropus tchadensis
Thought to be last common ancestor of both chimps and humans.

6.1 MYA
Orrorin tugenensis
Possibly the first ape to walk on two legs.

4.1 MYA
Australopithecus afarensis
Thought to be the ancestor of the genus *Homo*, to which modern humans belong.



2.2 MYA
Homo habilis
Called *habilis* (Latin for "handyman") because they may have been the first species to use tools.

600,000 YA
Homo heidelbergensis
Higher, broader skull to protect a larger brain than earlier species.



150,000 YA
Homo sapiens
Evolved in Africa, then spread worldwide, becoming the only surviving species of the *Homo* genus.

8 MYA

HUMAN ANCESTORS

About 7 million years ago, the ape family split into two branches – one would lead to chimpanzees, and the other was the line of human-like apes (hominins) that would eventually evolve into modern humans.

3.3 MYA
Australopithecus africanus
Ape-like, with a small brain but human-like teeth.

1 MYA
Homo erectus
As tall as modern humans, with a similar build.



350,000 YA
Homo neanderthalensis
Excellent hunters and tool-makers who thrived in the colder climate of Europe.



PRESENT